

# Astronauts Come Home After 237 Days in Space

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Four astronauts are back on Earth after more than seven months on the International Space Station. Their SpaceX **capsule** splashed down safely in the Pacific Ocean near Los Angeles on Thursday.

The Crew-12 team was NASA astronauts Jessica Meir and Jack Hathaway, European astronaut Sophie Adenot and Russian **cosmonaut** Andrey Fedyaev. They spent 237 days in space. They circled Earth more than 3,792 times and traveled over 100 million miles!

Rescue teams on ships quickly reached the **capsule**. After health checks, the crew was heading to NASA's Johnson Space Center in Houston.

In space, the crew did many science experiments. One tested ways to make **stem cells**, which might help treat sick people someday. Another tested a machine that makes **IV fluids**, the liquids doctors give patients. Other studies looked at food and blood flow in space.

NASA says this research will help astronauts stay healthy on future trips to the Moon and Mars. Jessica Meir also did four **spacewalks** on this mission.

## Word Treasure

**capsule** -- A small spacecraft that carries astronauts.

**cosmonaut** -- A Russian astronaut.

**stem cells** -- Special cells that can turn into many kinds of cells in the body.

**IV fluids** -- Liquids doctors give patients through a thin tube.

**spacewalks** -- Times when astronauts go outside their spacecraft in space suits.

## Background you need

The International Space Station is a big science lab that flies around Earth, where astronauts live for months.

Scientists study how space changes the body so astronauts can stay healthy on long trips to the Moon and Mars.

## Break it down

**WHO:** Crew-12 astronauts Jessica Meir, Jack Hathaway, Sophie Adenot and Andrey Fedyaev

**WHAT:** They returned safely after 237 days in space

**WHERE:** Splashdown in the Pacific Ocean near Los Angeles, after living on the International Space Station

**WHY:** Their experiments help astronauts stay healthy on future trips to the Moon and Mars

## Why it matters

The experiments could help future astronauts explore the Moon and Mars and may even help doctors treat sick people on Earth.

## Test what you remember

**1. How long were the astronauts in space?**

- ☐ (A) 7 days
- ☐ (B) 237 days
- ☐ (C) 3 years
- ☐ (D) 30 days

**2. Where did the capsule splash down?**

- ☐ (A) The Arctic
- ☐ (B) A lake in Texas
- ☐ (C) The Atlantic Ocean
- ☐ (D) The Pacific Ocean near Los Angeles

**3. How many astronauts were on Crew-12?**

- ☐ (A) Two
- ☐ (B) Four
- ☐ (C) Six
- ☐ (D) Ten

**4. How far did they travel?**

- ☐ (A) Over 1 billion miles
- ☐ (B) Exactly 237 miles
- ☐ (C) Over 100 million miles
- ☐ (D) About 1,000 miles

**5. What does the IV fluid machine make?**

- ☐ (A) Liquids doctors give patients
- ☐ (B) Rocket fuel
- ☐ (C) Drinking juice
- ☐ (D) Air to breathe

**6. Who did four spacewalks on this mission?**

- ☐ (A) Jack Hathaway
- ☐ (B) Sophie Adenot
- ☐ (C) Jessica Meir
- ☐ (D) Andrey Fedyaev

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: D 3: B 4: C 5: A 6: C

**MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):**